

Riccardo Di Cato

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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj

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Education

University of California San Diego

2021–present

Ph.D. in Economics (expected 2027)

Research areas: Development Economics and Political Economy

Advisors: Sara Lowes and Samuel Bazzi (co-chairs); Paul Niehaus, Gaurav Khanna, and Craig McIntosh

University of Bologna

2018

M.Sc. in Economics, LMEC (*summa cum laude*)

University of Pavia

2016

B.A. in Economics

Job Market Paper

Seeds of Market-Based Capitalism: Financial Innovation and China's Modernization *with Jiachen Li*

How do new economic ideas spread across different institutional environments? We examine this question by tracing the adoption of modern finance in China from the late nineteenth century to the present. Before 1936, as modern financial practices spread into China, we show that Christian missionaries contributed to their local adoption. Using a staggered difference-in-differences design, we find that missionary arrival increased modern banks by 31% and enterprises by 27%. Using newly compiled data on mission schools, publications, bankers, and elites, we provide evidence that practical education and knowledge diffusion facilitated the adoption of modern banking. We then estimate the long run effects of missionary exposure after 1949 by using the coincidental timing of railway construction relative to national missionary inflows. The historical banking advantage weakened under central planning but re-emerged after 1978 and remains visible today. Locations with greater historical missionary exposure have higher GDP, more enterprises, and greater foreign investment, indicating that missionaries shaped the geography of China's recent growth. Data on elites, scientists, and educational attainment suggest that the weakening and re-emergence of the banking advantage reflect complementarity between historically formed human capital and a policy environment supportive of market development. Overall, the successful adoption of new ideas requires both the local skills and knowledge needed to adopt them and an institutional environment in which they can be used.

Work in Progress

Same Faith, Different Politics: Religious Broadcasting and Voting in Italy and Spain *with Mattia Albertini*

Restricting Online Pornography and Violence Against Women: Evidence from India and the United States *with Santiago Cantillo*

Increasing Female Employment in the Automotive Sector in India *with Garima Sharma, Anant Nyshadham, and Achyuta Adhvaryu*

Religious Broadcasting and Belief Formation in Tanzania *with Mattia Albertini*

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research	2022
Research Assistant (Prof. Samuel Bazzi)	
Bocconi University	2019–2021
Research Associate (Prof. Nicola Limodio and Prof. Filippo De Marco)	
Harvard University	2018–2019
Field Research Associate in the DRC (Profs. N. Nunn, J. A. Robinson, S. Lowes, and J. Weigel)	
Entrepreneurial Venture	2015–2020
Founded and managed a hospitality business operating three tourist residences in Italy	

Presentations

SIOE Conference, INSEAD	2026
HHDI–NIDE Workshop, Belfast	2026
IRES Workshop, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, Chapman University	2026
ASREC Conference, George Mason University	2025
SOCAL Conference, UCLA	2025
DevPEC Conference, UC Berkeley	2025
University of Bologna WiP Seminar	2025
Migration and Development Conference, Bologna	2024
Boston University Center for the Study of Asia	2024

Teaching Experience

University of California San Diego	2021–present
<i>Graduate:</i> Financial Accounting; Quantitative Methods II; Quantitative Methods III	
<i>Undergraduate:</i> Microeconomics (principles and intermediate); Financial Accounting; The Indian Economy	
Bocconi University	2020
<i>Undergraduate:</i> Financial Markets and Institutions; Public Finance	

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

Cindy Vojtech Summer Research Prize in Economics, UC San Diego (\$1,667)	2026
IHS Research & Travel Grant (\$2,500)	2026
Summer Research Grant, UC San Diego (\$2,600)	2024–2025
Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics (\$6,885)	2023
21st Century India Center Travel Grant, UC San Diego (\$8,500)	2023
TRELS Grant, UC San Diego (\$1,000)	2022
Overseas Scholarship, Université de Montréal	2018
Erasmus Scholarship, Université Pierre Mendès France	2015

Referee Service

Journal of Development Economics; Economic Development and Cultural Change, Mission Studies

Mentoring and Community Involvement

Co-founder, Undergraduate–Graduate Economic Research Lab, UC San Diego
 Co-founder and co-host, Backstory Podcast at UC San Diego
 Organizer and director, church summer camp, Omegna, Italy; college-student mentor
 Co-founder, “Yes, I Care” community-meeting project; volunteer with Suñu Diwaan, Senegal

Additional Information

<i>Programming</i>	Stata, R, ArcGIS, L ^A T _E X, GeoODK (advanced); Python (intermediate); Matlab (basic)
<i>Languages</i>	<i>Native:</i> Italian. <i>Fluent:</i> English, French. <i>Intermediate:</i> Spanish.
<i>Citizenship</i>	Italian citizen; U.S. permanent resident; married to a Spanish-American citizen